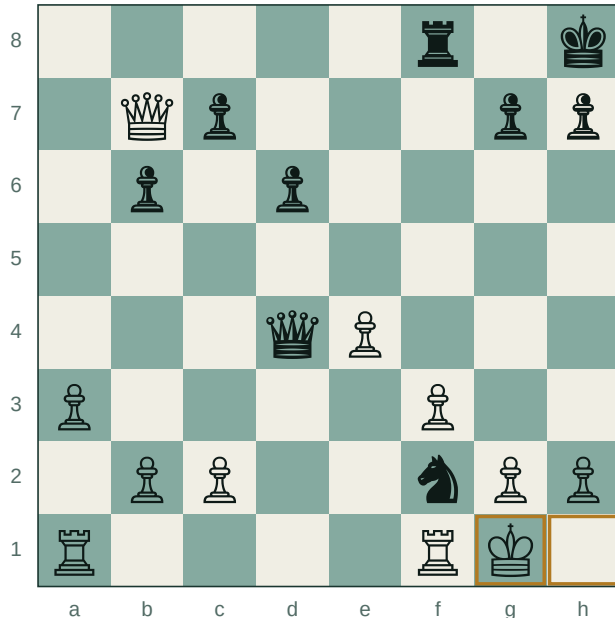


Smothered mates: Black, move 21

Smothered mates

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Kg1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Nh3+ 22. Kh1 Qg1+ 23. Rxf1 Nf2#

21...Nh3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The changed line means the queen on d4 attacks the king on g1. Recorded reply: **22.Kh1**.

22...Qg1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From g1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on f1. Recorded reply: **23.Rxf1**.

23...Nf2# Mate: knight on f2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on b7. Check for tactical protection.